



East End Cultural District, Talento Bilingue de Houston, Photo by Dan Joyce

CREATIVE CONNECTIONS:

Strategic Framework for the Houston Cultural Districts

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The Impact of the Cultural Districts

This project engaged residents, business owners, artists and visitors to gather their insights on the Cultural Districts of Houston. While every person had something slightly different to say, the big takeaway was clear: the Cultural Districts enhance the cultural and economic vibrancy of the city of Houston, while serving as places where friends, family and visitors come together and connect.

ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT

The Houston Cultural Districts contribute to the **ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT** of Houston by:

Generating new business opportunities and revenue streams for District nonprofits, businesses, artists, and cultural practitioners

Supporting the financial sustainability and growth of District nonprofits, businesses, artists, and cultural practitioners

Attracting neighborhood development

Some Key Stats:

- In 2022, the Districts generated \$8.6 million in local sales tax and \$6 million in state sales tax
- In 2022, Houston Cultural District nonprofits totaled \$503.8 million in annual expenditures
- Cultural District nonprofits sustain 4,100 full-time equivalent jobs
- Taxable revenue from Texas' arts and culture industry has increased by 30% over the last 10 years
- 60% of nonprofit survey respondents reported increased access to funding as a result of being located in a Cultural District

CULTURAL VIBRANCY

The Houston Cultural Districts contribute to the **CULTURAL VIBRANCY** of Houston by...

Cultivating a rich and diverse array of arts and cultural experiences

Attracting visitors and increasing access to arts and culture for the people who live, work, or play in Houston

Fostering creativity, well-being, and arts and cultural appreciation

Celebrating neighborhood creativity, preserving cultural legacy, and safeguarding local arts and cultural ecosystems.

Some Key Stats:

- 84 arts and culture nonprofits, 47 for-profit arts businesses, 28 parks, 17 heritage sites, and more than 400 artist studios across the seven districts.
- 11.2 million annual visitors
- Nearly 600 annual productions and exhibitions within the districts
- More than 230,000 K-12 students engaged annually by district member programming
- In conversation residents reinforced the value of the arts: "Being here makes me realize how art makes Houston a better place to live!"

COMMUNITY COHESION

The Houston Cultural Districts contribute to the **COMMUNITY COHESION** of Houston by:

Gathering friends and families

Fostering civic pride and engagement

Building connections within Houston's arts and culture sector

Catalyzing mutually beneficial cross-sector collaborations

Some Key Stats:

- 62,700 Houstonians live in a Cultural District
- 88% of surveyed District residents shared that they are more likely to invite friends and family to their neighborhood because they live in a Cultural District
- 14,000 Houstonians volunteer at District nonprofits annually
- 78% of surveyed visitors felt more invested in Houston's future as a result of Cultural District experiences
- 80% of surveyed nonprofits reported a stronger sense of community as a result of Cultural District participation

A Vision and Plan for the Future

This project culminated in the development of a shared vision and plan, highlighting how the Houston Cultural Districts can leverage their strengths and capabilities in order to increase the connection, visibility, and sustainability of arts and culture in Houston.

The result is a two part strategy - a purposeful effort to grow the network of arts and cultural ambassadors in Houston and a parallel strategy that brings visitors and residents together to experience and celebrate Houston's cultural vibrancy through a series of creative placemaking and storytelling projects.

The title for this multi-year effort is 'Creative Connections', reflecting its aspirations to deepen relationships across the arts ecosystem, enhance physical connectivity between the Cultural Districts, and provide new connective opportunities for visitors and residents seeking creative experiences.

Vision: We envision Houston as **a world-renowned center for cultural arts**, where local artists, residents, and visitors uplift and benefit from the city's unique and diverse arts and cultural assets.

CHAMPION

Strategy Overview: Grow the network of arts and culture champions in Houston through building capacity for advocacy and developing partnerships beyond the arts & culture sector, in order to advance shared policy and funding priorities.

**A1: Build Capacity
for Arts Advocacy**

**A2: Partnerships &
Relationship Building**

Strategy Purpose: To have a well-funded arts and culture sector that is involved in the everyday decisions that shape life in Houston.

CELEBRATE

Strategy Overview: Bring visitors and residents together to experience and celebrate Houston's cultural vibrancy through a series of creative placemaking and storytelling projects across the Cultural Districts.

**B1: Unified
District Activations**

**B2: Stories
to New Audiences**

Strategy Purpose: To raise awareness of Houston's rich and diverse arts and cultural assets in a way that builds connection and fosters civic pride, ultimately leading to increased recognition, engagement, and financial sustainability for the sector.



Houston Museum District, Museum of Fine Arts Houston's Beck Building, Interior, Photo by Allyson Huntsman

Introduction

Houston is a place full of arts and cultural activity - boasting an impressive set of institutions, performing & visual arts organizations, and cultural destinations. Collectively, they are an expression of the city's unique history and unparalleled ethnic and cultural diversity. These arts and cultural assets and experiences, and the people who create them, are the beating heart of Houston. Vexingly, to many who are part of the processes of cultural and creative production, they feel like one of the city's best kept secrets.

There is a large body of research that highlights the positive impact of arts, culture, and creativity on quality of life. Municipalities across the world are prioritizing and planning for how to elevate and sustain their cultural assets, and Houston increasingly is realizing the importance of doing the same. This was evident in the release of the 2015 Arts and Culture Plan for the City of Houston, which was a major step forward in articulating a shared vision for public support of the arts, including specific goals around highlighting and developing cultural arts initiatives that celebrate Houston's diverse artists, cultures and communities.

Creative Connections focuses on how seven Cultural Districts in Houston — wide-ranging in their variety and history, but all concentrated within a 10 minute commute from the downtown area - can work together to build awareness of the arts and culture scene in Houston, and in turn ensure that more artists, residents, and visitors can uplift and benefit from the city's unique and diverse cultural assets.

During the planning process, participants frequently raised two important areas for consideration. Firstly, there is a desire to engage and attract the large number of people who live and work in the Greater Houston region rather than build a strategy solely for tourists and visitors. Secondly, the historical processes for funding and sharing arts and culture have not been inclusive and equitable, which has caused distrust and fragmentation in the sector. A successful collective effort will require finding a balance between residents and visitor desires, and a deliberate attempt to center inclusive processes and investments, so that efforts to bring additional resources and awareness to the sector do not replicate and deepen historical inequities.

The plan outlines two key areas where the districts have an opportunity to make meaningful shifts.

- The first strategy — **Champion** — attempts to grow the network of arts and cultural ambassadors in Houston, by building capacity for advocacy and developing new partnerships outside of the sector. By building power for the sector, these efforts seek to advance shared policy and funding priorities, resulting in a well-funded arts and culture sector that is involved in the everyday decisions that shape life in Houston.
- The second strategy - **Celebrate** - seeks to bring visitors and residents together to experience and celebrate Houston's cultural vibrancy through a series of creative placemaking and storytelling projects across the Cultural Districts and beyond. Ultimately, this strategy seeks to raise awareness of Houston's rich and diverse arts and cultural assets in a way that builds connection, fosters civic pride, and stimulates the cultural economy.

These are both multi-year efforts, and accordingly this plan will require sustained coordination and investment over time. However, over time these efforts will pay for themselves manifold, as additional resources are brought in through advocacy, increased visitorship, and philanthropic investments. While this plan was coordinated by the seven Houston Cultural Districts, the vision and hope is that the benefits of the plan, and the implementation of it, is something that brings together members of the arts and culture sector from across the city and region, unifying around a common purpose and vision. We hope you'll join us.

A successful collective effort will require finding a balance between residents and visitor desires and a deliberate attempt to center inclusive processes and investments.

What Are the Seven Houston Cultural Districts?

Houston's Cultural Districts (HCDs) collectively represent a cross-section of the diverse neighborhoods and arts experiences that make Houston unique. While each district has its distinct identity, function, and goal, all of them utilize art and culture to educate, entertain, and enhance the quality of life. Moreover, they play a crucial role in supporting our community and city economy.

Collectively the Cultural Districts share a desire to preserve, strengthen, and sustain their districts. This, in turn, will attract investment, economic growth, and creative/cultural engagement -- not only to the Cultural Districts, but for the arts across Houston.



The following three typologies were created during this project to help describe the types of Cultural Districts that exist in Houston.

CREATOR-FOCUSED DISTRICTS

Arts District, Midtown

Creator-Focused Districts offer robust engagement opportunities for independent artists in the greater Houston area and have a high concentration of for-profit arts businesses, such as galleries and artist studios. Programs produced by these Cultural Districts include art markets, artist residencies, artist microgrants, and consolidated postings for artist opportunities and resources.

HERITAGE-FOCUSED DISTRICTS

5th Ward, East End, Third Ward

Heritage-Focused Districts effectively prioritize the celebration of neighborhood creativity and preservation of cultural legacy. They contain a high concentration of heritage sites, and programming produced by these Cultural Districts includes experiences rooted in cultural heritage and legacy, artist councils, and town halls for the neighborhood's creative community.

INSTITUTION-FOCUSED DISTRICTS

Museum District, Houston Theater District

Institution-Focused Districts offer a high concentration of well-resourced arts and cultural organizations that drive visibility and accessibility of arts and culture in Houston. Museums and theatres in these districts provide a diverse array of fine arts and cultural experiences. Governed by a membership structure, these Cultural Districts are spearheaded by representatives from the member organizations.

How ‘Creative Connections’ Fits into the Broader Arts & Cultural Ecosystem

The Cultural Districts play a unique role in the Arts & Cultural ecosystem. They are varied enough to provide a window into Houston's diverse neighborhoods and cultural activities, while still not encompassing the entirety of the city's rich arts and culture tapestry. This planning process sought to balance those realities — understanding the specific capabilities of the Districts, and also the needs of the broader sector.

The result is a plan for how the Cultural Districts believe they can make the most impact on the whole sector. The plan outlines the leverage points where the Cultural Districts are positioned to lead in a manner that will not just address a short-term need for their districts, but catalyze change for the broader system.

This plan's systems change approach is informed by FSG's Water of Systems Change framework, which encourages strategy to look beyond the surface level outcomes, and to instead focus on how (1) policies, practices, & funding, (2) relationships & power dynamics, and (3) mental models may need to shift to create sustained impact. See Appendix B for an initial mapping of underlying conditions that contribute to the outcomes this plan seeks to shift in the Houston arts and culture ecosystem.

THROUGHOUT THE PLAN, STRATEGY DEVELOPMENT HAS BEEN INFORMED BY THIS FRAMEWORK, ENSURING THAT STRATEGIES SUGGESTED MEET THE FOLLOWING CRITERIA:

- 1 Prioritizing work that will have a lasting positive impact...
- 2 where changing one thing will have a ripple effect to improve other things across the ecosystem...
- 3 ... AND where the Cultural Districts are positioned to be a champion and key driver.

Systems Change Framework

Outcomes are a result of other conditions in the system.

There are three interdependent conditions (seen on the right) that typically play significant roles in holding a problem in place.



OUTCOMES

STRUCTURAL

Policies, Practices & Funding

RELATIONAL

Relationships & Power Dynamics

TRANSFORMATIVE

Mental Models

Planning Process

This plan was developed through an inclusive and expansive year-long discovery and planning process designed to yield two core outputs: (1) HCD Plan: a vision and plan for the districts to build awareness of the Houston arts sector's unique diversity, variety, impact, and potential, and (2) HCD Evaluation Report: a framework for measuring and articulating the impact of the Cultural Districts.



The process incorporated the voices of almost 1,000 individuals connected to the Cultural Districts, including artists, non-profits, businesses, leaders of small, medium, and large arts and culture institutions, community members, and visitors. Additionally, the plan strategies were informed by an extensive literature review and research into peer cities. The process included three in-person convenings, including two strategy design sessions with key stakeholders across the Cultural Districts, and one December convening with artists and culture workers from across Greater Houston focused on how best to collaborate across the ecosystem.



267 Survey Responses



420 Visitor Reflections



Peer Cities Study



Literature Review



140 People Engaged
in Convenings



6 Focus Groups and
Strategy Sessions



One-on-One Interviews
with City Leaders

Initial Learnings

The strategies encompassed in the plan are built upon the insights from diverse stakeholders captured during the discovery phase. Findings from the discovery phase were synthesized into three core need areas, and provided the foundation for the creation of a unified vision.



CREATORS

Artists and culture-workers who have the resources to live, create, and prosper



CONNECTION

A connected arts and cultural ecosystem with sustainable funding, infrastructure, and strong institutions



EXPERIENCES

Accessible arts and cultural experiences that create a sense of place and reflect the city's diversity & vibrancy

VISION

We envision Houston as a world-renowned center for cultural arts, where local artists, residents, and visitors uplift and benefit from the city's unique and diverse arts and cultural assets.

During the strategy design convenings, participants built upon these findings and began identifying solutions around five corresponding design areas, focusing on how the Cultural Districts could best leverage their resources and capabilities to address the needs and work towards the shared vision. Dozens of participants from across the arts & cultural ecosystem engaged with these five design areas to subsequently create the core strategies of the plan encompassed in the following pages.

Advocacy for Sustained Funding

Supporting Houston-Based Artists

Increasing Accessibility of Information on Arts & Culture in Houston

Activating the Cultural Districts

Using Art to Tell Houston's Unknown Arts & Culture Stories



5th Ward Cultural Arts District, Photo by Risky Cereal

See Appendix A for a more robust detailing of the findings from the discovery process.

Plan Overview

The following pages outline the Houston Cultural Districts' (HCDs) approach to advancing the shared vision for the ecosystem over the next 5 years.

The HCDs will embark upon two core strategies, activated by two initiatives each, and supported by eight core values.

These strategies, initiatives, goals, and values have been developed and refined through extensive collaboration with HCD leaders, member organizations, artists, and community members. As such, they have the shared ownership and buy-in necessary for effective implementation and ecosystem-level change. If realized - these strategies have the opportunity to catalyze transformation for the entire sector, and subsequently for the city as a whole.

PLAN VISION, PURPOSE & VALUES

Plan Purpose: To leverage the strength and capabilities of the Houston Cultural Districts in order to increase the connection, visibility, and sustainability of arts and culture in Houston.

PLAN VALUES

Invest in Local Artists & Culture Workers

Increase Equity & Access

Break Down Barriers to Collaboration

Engage Authentically & Transparently

Prioritize Cultural Diversity & Inclusion

Support Artists and Organizations of All Sizes

Innovate & Dream Big

Recognize Each District's Unique Context

Vision: Houston as a world-renowned center for cultural arts, where local artists, residents, and visitors uplift and benefit from the city's unique and diverse arts and cultural assets.

CHAMPION

Strategy Overview: Grow the network of arts and culture champions in Houston through building capacity for advocacy and developing partnerships beyond the arts & culture sector, in order to advance shared policy and funding priorities.

A1: Build Capacity for Arts Advocacy

A2: Partnerships & Relationship Building

Strategy Purpose: To have a well-funded arts and culture sector that is involved in the everyday decisions that shape life in Houston.

CELEBRATE

Strategy Overview: Bring visitors and residents together to experience and celebrate Houston's cultural vibrancy through a series of creative placemaking and storytelling projects across the Cultural Districts.

B1: Unified District Activations

B2: Stories to New Audiences

Strategy Purpose: To raise awareness of Houston's rich and diverse arts and cultural assets in a way that builds connection and fosters civic pride, ultimately leading to increased recognition, engagement, and financial sustainability for the sector.



Arts District Houston, Sip and Stroll Art Tour at RUBY Projects, photo by Viva La Marx Photography

Mapping Funding Streams

From the outset of this project, one of the shared desires across constituent groups has been to increase the availability and prevalence of funding for arts and culture in Houston.

Part of the project research involved creating a funding map that visualized key funding streams within the arts & cultural ecosystem, and identified opportunity areas where new or existing funding streams could be activated or deepened.

This map is neither fully exhaustive nor detailed enough to capture the various funding mechanisms for the ecosystem, but it aims to serve as a starting point for ongoing resource mapping and identification. While the current plan will likely not involve targeting all potential areas, at a high level the Champion strategy lays the groundwork for accessing increased public funding, and the Celebrate strategy aims to increase revenues from consumers and patrons. The plan as a whole is structured to be a vehicle for raising and increasing philanthropic investment in the arts sector and its collective potential.

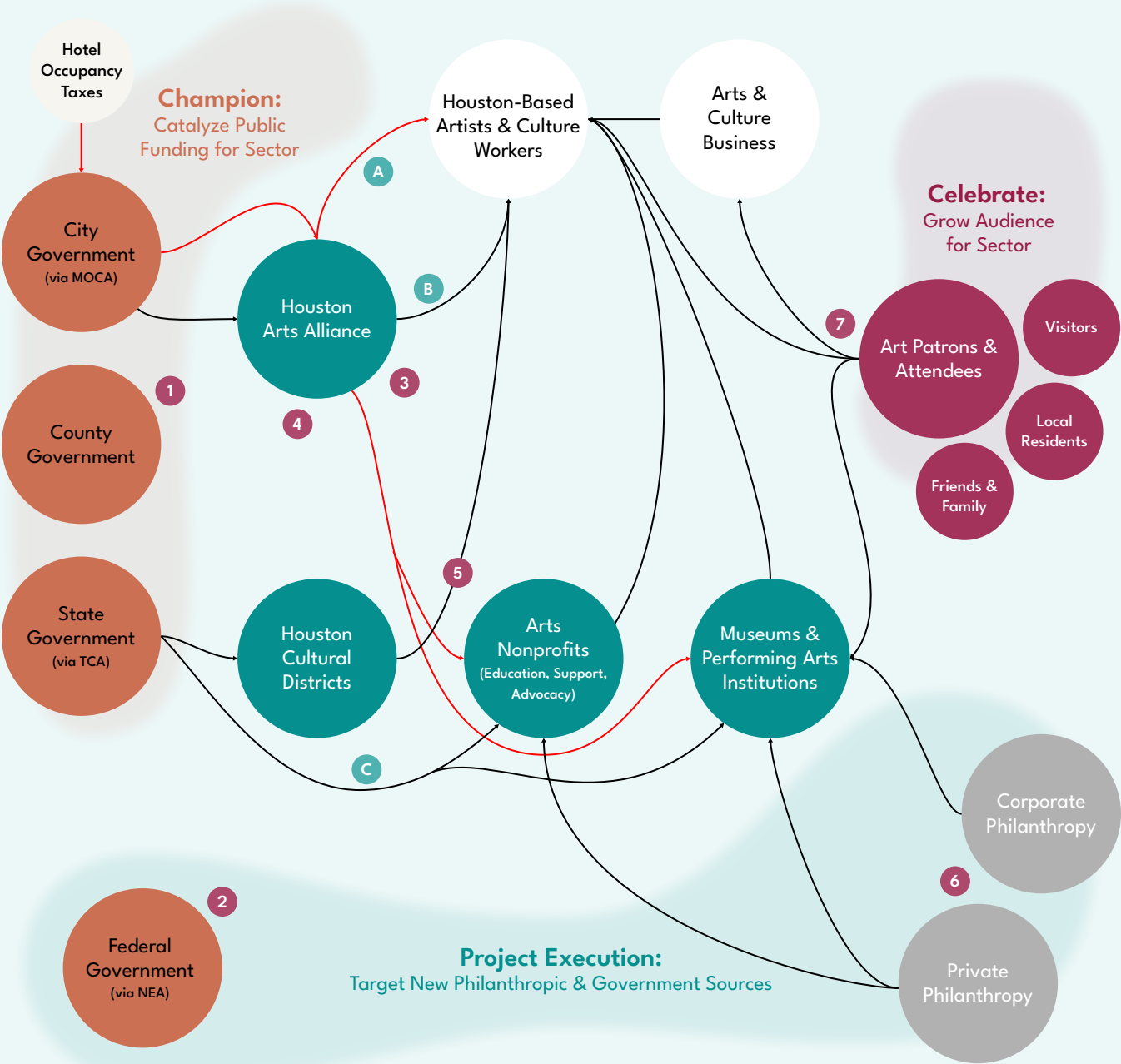
Notes on the Current State

- A. The individual artist HOT (Hotel Occupancy Tax) Funding from Houston ARTs Alliance is typically limited only for artists within incorporated Houston City limits.
- B. The Civic Art Program directs 1.75% of the budget for eligible City-funded construction projects be spent to integrate artwork and the ideas of artists in public spaces, and to conserve the City Art Collection.
- C. TCA (Texas Commission for the Arts) funding is available for organizations with budgets greater than \$250,000 located in a Cultural District. Cultural Districts are also eligible to apply but do not distribute or allocate the other grants.

Strategic Funding Opportunities

- 1. Build advocacy path to identify new funding sources at county level.
- 2. Target NEA grants for collaborative creative placemaking initiatives across districts.
- 3. Revise Civic Art Ordinance to broaden definition of public art to be more expansive.
- 4. Protect HOT Funding from reallocation away from arts & culture.
- 5. Explore role as sub-granting organizations, building on existing program within Midtown Cultural Arts District.
- 6. Target non-traditional arts funders interested in intersecting issues (i.e. equity, health, economic opportunity).
- 7. Increase flow of resources from private sector (tickets, purchases, in-kind support) via effective marketing.

Funding Map & Strategic Opportunities



KEY → Funding Flows → Hotel Occupancy Taxes (HOT Funds) ● Nonprofits ● Government ● Philanthropy ● Consumers

Strategy A Overview: Champion

Strategy Overview: Grow the network of arts and culture champions in Houston through building capacity for advocacy and developing partnerships beyond the arts & culture sector, in order to advance shared policy and funding priorities.

Strategy Purpose: To have a well-funded arts and culture sector that is involved in the everyday decisions that shape life in Houston.

A1: Build Capacity for Arts Advocacy

Initiative Overview: In concert with existing arts advocacy efforts across the Greater Houston Area and the state, plan and convene trainings for arts and culture advocacy, develop engaging and informative collateral, and connect newly equipped champions to existing opportunities.

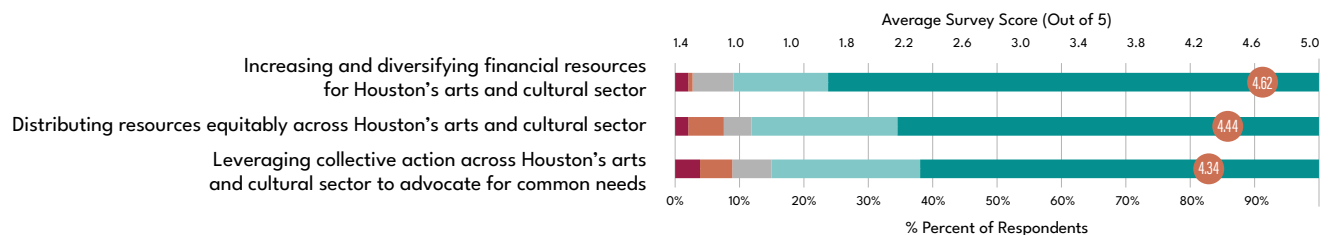
A2: Partnerships & Relationship Building

Initiative Overview: Build sector influence through deepening relationships with decision-making bodies, (i.e. Greater Houston Partnerships and Houston First), as well as Houston's government and business leaders.

STRATEGY BACKGROUND

Despite the wealth of resources available in Houston, the city's arts and culture scene suffers from a lack of financial investment and engagement in arts and culture by local, regional and state decision-makers, which contributes to the larger issue of inadequate pools of funding for arts and culture. The arts and culture sector has spent important time focusing on appropriate and equitable distribution of the current pool of public funding; however, there is agreement that moving forward there is a need to pair equitable distribution with an increase in total funding.

When compared to peer cities, Houston falls short in public funding allocated to arts and culture, and has relatively underdeveloped infrastructure for arts advocacy. Changing this dynamic will require coordinated effort to influence public policy. Stakeholders identified both county and state funding as potential public sources for additional revenue, and discussed the importance of braiding public funding with other sources of funding. However, advocacy knowledge and participation is limited and disparate across the arts and cultural sector, and there is no city or county-wide body that advocates for common needs. Coordinated advocacy is critical for a successful path forward. Past efforts, such as participation in the Texas Arts Advocacy Summit at the capitol, and the recent securing of \$5M in American Rescue Plan funding serve as examples of coordinated advocacy to build upon and strengthen.



Data Insight: Over 85% of the 280 survey respondents ranked the following statements as "Important" or "Very Important" for the future of arts & culture in Houston.

Champion Initiatives Details

A1. Building Capacity for Arts Advocacy

A1 Goal: A citywide network of arts advocates across sectors working to shift practices in line with articulated policy agenda.

A1 OVERVIEW

In concert with existing arts advocacy efforts across the Greater Houston Area and the state, the HCDs will:

1. Connect newly champions to existing opportunities
2. Plan and convene trainings for arts and culture advocacy
3. Develop engaging and informative collateral

ADDITIONAL INITIATIVE DETAILS

This initiative will build upon and collaborate with existing advocacy efforts, particularly at the State level (e.g., Texas Arts Advocacy Day). These state-level efforts will focus primarily on connecting newly-engaged individuals to existing advocacy efforts. This initiative will also include the development of new forums at the city-level and county-level where there is not yet advocacy infrastructure (e.g., establishing a Houston Arts Advocacy Day). Additionally, these efforts will be designed to ensure accessibility to new and existing opportunities.

Potential Target Audiences for Trainings

- The advocacy trainings and recruitment efforts would be designed primarily for the following audiences:
- Artists/arts workers
- Arts leaders across Houston
- Business and municipal leaders
- Non-profit organizations of all sizes

A2: Partnerships & Relationship Building

A2 Goal: Inclusion of arts and cultural representatives in conversations and plans around tourism, economic development, and other key systems that impact the arts sector and shape the lives of residents.

A2 OVERVIEW

Build sector influence through deepening relationships with decision-making bodies, as well as Houston's government and business leaders.

ADDITIONAL INITIATIVE DETAILS

Conduct a power mapping process to develop a shared list of decision-makers, and engage HCD member organizations in subsequent outreach and engagement efforts. Develop a shared script and engagement protocol to guide efforts.

Focus initial efforts on:

- Councils of Elected Officials (City Council, County Commissioners)
- Economic development bodies
- Tourism bodies

While the first initiative is more focused on grassroots activation, this area is focused largely on "grass-tops" relationships — building influence with key bodies and entities that can be involved in a coalition to support arts and culture in Houston.



Potential Policy Agenda

City:

- Deeper investment & engagement with arts & culture from Mayoral administration and key leaders
- Broadened definition of public art to increase flexibility of Civic Art Ordinance (Houston's Percent for Art Program).

County:

- Creation of county-wide arts advocacy organization
- Increased financial investments in Arts & Culture

State:

- Increased financial investments in Arts & Culture

Strategy B Overview: Celebrate

Strategy Overview: Bring visitors and residents together to experience and celebrate Houston's cultural vibrancy through a series of creative placemaking and storytelling projects across the Cultural Districts.

Strategy Purpose: To raise awareness of Houston's rich and diverse arts and cultural assets in a way that builds connection and fosters civic pride, ultimately leading to increased recognition, engagement, and financial sustainability for the sector.

B1: Unified District Activations

Initiative Overview: Activate the HCDs through diverse place-based art installations or events within the HCD parks that showcase and increase visibility of Houston's cultural identity, create a sense of place, and foster community. Launch with a unified marketing approach that ties the HCDs together and clarifies distinct district identities.

B2: Stories to New Audiences

Initiative Overview: Fund creative projects that uplift the arts and culture stories of Houston and bring them to new audiences. Engage a firm to execute a public relations campaign that centers Houston art and artists in the campaign content and creation process.

STRATEGY BACKGROUND

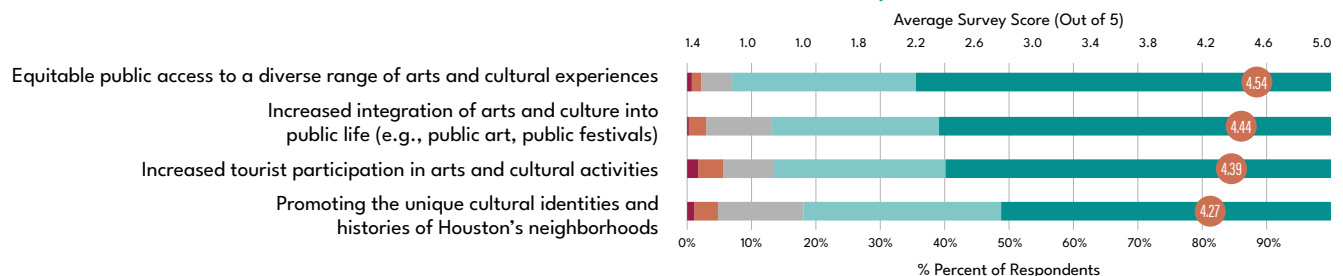
Those who are tapped into the arts and cultural ecosystem of the city see Houston as brimming with cultural assets: museums, performing arts venues, historical neighborhood-based organizations & collectives, and much more. However, among many residents and visitors, there is a lack of awareness of the richness of arts and culture in Houston.

Individuals engaged in this discovery and planning process offered a variety of explanations for this disconnect. Compared to other major cities, local stakeholders noted that Houston lacks prominent historical narratives and features, and is hampered by an absence of obvious and accessible street life. Additionally, many within and outside of the city perceive Houston's brand as tied to space exploration, business, the energy sector, the medical center, and sports.

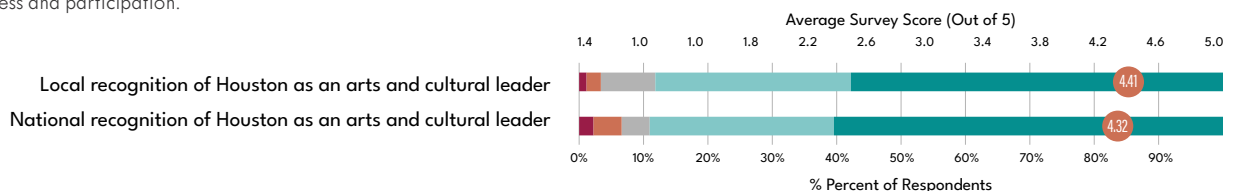
While the recent attention on the city's food scene and diversity has begun to expand its brand, to many the depth and breadth of Houston's culture remains unknown.

In response to these challenges, there is a desire to celebrate Houston's arts and culture assets -- both for the residents and visitors of Houston, and for new audiences across the world. For Houston residents and visitors, participants see an opportunity for strong wayfinding anchored in experiences that bring people together and uplift the identity of neighborhoods within the Houston Cultural Districts. To reach individuals who are not physically in the city, there is a desire to tell the story of arts and culture in Houston not through another marketing campaign, but by using art itself as the medium.

The Future of Arts & Culture in Houston: What's Important?



Data Insight: When asked what was "most important to the future of arts and culture in Houston", survey respondents expressed overwhelming support for increased access and participation.



Data Insight: Survey respondents scored recognition - both local and national - as important for the future of arts and culture in Houston. Many respondents emphasized the richness of arts and culture already present, and the need for better marketing and storytelling.

Celebrate Initiatives Details

B1. Unified District Activations

B1 Goal: Widely advertised and successful set of placemaking projects across the districts that bring awareness to arts and culture in Houston, are meaningful for residents, and drive visitation and support from locals and visitors.

B1 OVERVIEW

Activate the HCDs through diverse place-based art installations or events within the HCD parks that showcase and increase visibility of Houston's cultural identity, create a sense of place, and foster community. Launch with a unified marketing approach that ties the Districts together and clarifies distinct district identities.

ADDITIONAL INITIATIVE DETAILS

Project Identification: There will be a shared application process and rubric across the HCDs to support call for submissions. Project identification will be an inclusive, open submission process. The process will include some unified elements, and some elements that are unique to each HCD. HCDs will provide some input on other HCDs' activations in line with the unified thematic and marketing approach; however, project selection will be primarily decided by the HCD in which the project will be exhibited.

Ideal projects will incorporate accessibility, transportation, and/or walkability as intentional elements of activation design.

Exhibited projects may be newly created or pre-existing.

The HCDs will engage in multiple rounds of activations over the course of the 5 years of the plan.

B2. Bringing Houston's Stories to New Audiences

B2 Goal: New audiences are exposed to stories of arts and culture in Houston, prompting them to elevate, share, and support the city's unique and diverse cultural assets.

B2 OVERVIEW

Fund creative projects that uplift the arts and culture stories of Houston, using diverse art as the storytelling medium. Engage a firm to execute a public relations campaign that centers Houston art and artists in the campaign content and creation process.

ADDITIONAL INITIATIVE DETAILS

This initiative will be the fourth to be launched. Further implementation details will be developed in Years 1 and 2 of plan implementation. Examples include:

- Process for identifying, documenting and elevating local stories for documentation
- Creative distribution model, including analysis of film festivals and diverse digital channels

Throughout this discovery and planning process, participants emphasized the importance of avoiding a definitive or all-encompassing portrayal of Houston's arts and culture. Instead, they suggested emphasizing its continually growing, changing, and evolving nature.



Third Ward Cultural District, University Museum at TSU interior with Isiah, photo by Alex Barber

Our Approach to Measurement

As part of this planning process, the Cultural Districts engaged in a **robust evaluation process** to develop a **place-based and HCD-specific framework for modeling and measuring their impact**. This framework **articulates the current and potential value of the Houston Cultural Districts**, and includes corresponding tools for ongoing measurement of this value. See the Impact Framework below and the 'Value & Potential of the Houston Cultural Districts' report for the qualitative and quantitative evidence of these benefits, as well as areas for growth



The Houston Cultural Districts contribute to the **ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT** of Houston. The HCDs:

- Generate new business opportunities and revenue streams for District nonprofits, businesses, artists, and cultural practitioners
- Support the financial sustainability and growth of District nonprofits, businesses, artists, and cultural practitioners
- Attract neighborhood development



The Houston Cultural Districts contribute to the **COMMUNITY COHESION** of Houston. The HCDs:

- Gather friends and families
- Foster civic pride and engagement
- Build connections within Houston's arts and culture sector
- Catalyze mutually beneficial cross-sector collaborations



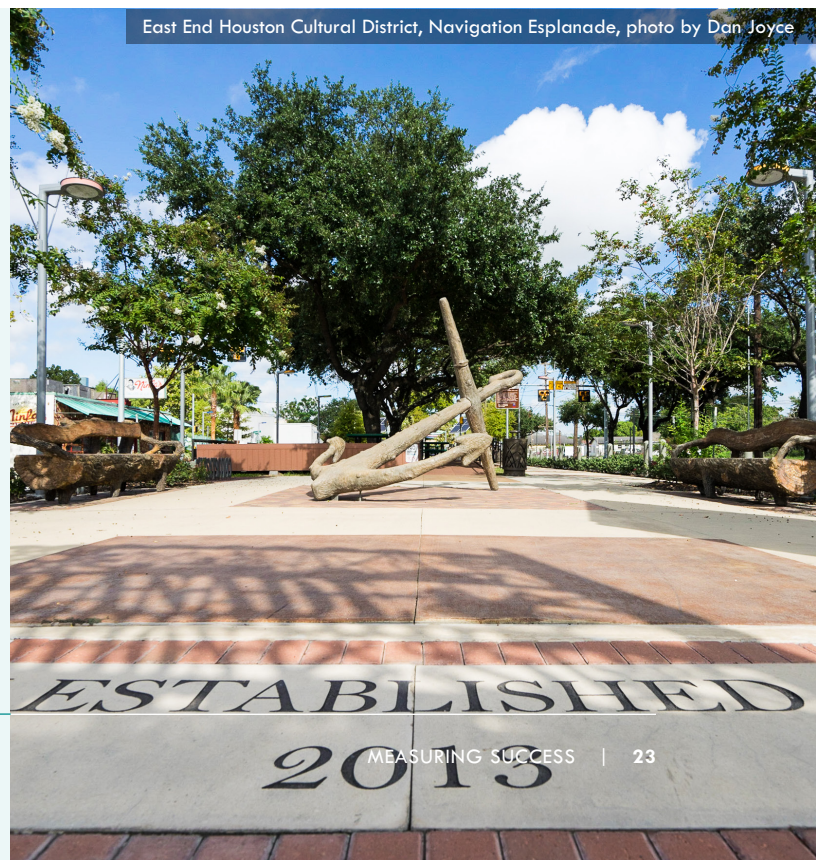
The Houston Cultural Districts contribute to the **CULTURAL VIBRANCY** of Houston. The HCDs:

- Cultivate a rich and diverse array of arts and cultural experiences
- Attract visitors and increase access to arts and culture for the people who live, work, or play in Houston
- Foster creativity, well-being, and arts and cultural appreciation
- Celebrate neighborhood creativity, preserve cultural legacy, and safeguard their District's arts and cultural ecosystem

Connecting Plan Strategies to the HCDs' Impact Framework

The Cultural Districts are one part of a much larger arts and cultural ecosystem in Houston. Rather than seeking to create entirely new approaches that fall outside of their strengths and capabilities, **the strategies identified in this plan are designed to focus on deepening HCDs' existing impact pathways** for the benefit of nonprofits, businesses, artists, residents & cultural practitioners within the HCDs and Houston more broadly.

The plan measurement framework on the next page maps the plan initiatives to the HCD impact framework, which will be used as the foundation for plan measurement. You can see the specific outputs and outcomes that will be measured in the logic models captured in Appendix C.



Measuring Success

Strategies

CHAMPION

Convening and Aligning Diverse Groups to Advance Shared Policy and Funding Priorities

A1. Build Capacity for Arts Advocacy

Desired Result: Citywide network of arts advocates across sectors working to shift practices in line with articulated policy agenda.

A2. Partnerships & Relationship Building

Desired Result: Inclusion of arts and cultural representatives in conversations and plans around tourism, economic development, and other key systems that impact the arts sector and shape the lives of residents.

CELEBRATE

Bringing Visitors, Residents, and Artists Together to Uplift Houston's Cultural Vibrancy

B1. Unified District Activations
Desired Result: Widely advertised and successful set of placemaking projects that bring awareness to arts and culture in Houston, are meaningful for residents, and drive visitation and support from locals and visitors.

B2. Bringing Houston's Stories to New Audiences
Desired Result: New audiences are exposed to stories of arts & culture in Houston, prompting them to elevate, share, and support the city's unique and diverse cultural assets.

Areas of Impact

Gather friends & family

Foster civic pride & engagement

Build connections within Houston's arts and culture sector

Catalyze mutually beneficial cross-sector collaboration

Generate new revenue streams & business opportunities for District nonprofits, businesses, artists, & cultural practitioners

Support financial sustainability and growth of District nonprofits, businesses, artists, & cultural practitioners

Attract neighborhood development

Cultivate rich and diverse array of arts and culture experiences

Attract visitors & increase access to arts and culture

Foster creativity, well-being, and arts and culture appreciation

Celebrate neighborhood creativity, preserve cultural legacy, & safeguard District's arts and culture ecosystem

COMMUNITY COHESION

ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT

CULTURAL VIBRANCY

Vision

Houston is a world-renowned center for cultural arts, where local artists, residents and visitors uplift and benefit from the city's unique and diverse arts and cultural assets

Collaborative Implementation Approach

Collaboration is not just an important element of this plan, it is fundamental to its strategies and to its success. There is broad agreement that there are systemic challenges inhibiting Houston's arts and cultural sector from realizing its full potential, including historic inequities regarding access to funding and due recognition. This has contributed to sector fragmentation and in some cases resulted in a significant erosion of trust. The discussions held as a part of this project led arts and culture community members to underscore that any efforts to move forward as whole and progress toward systems-level change must also include a committed investment in trust-building and reconciliation.

In keeping with the overall project approach, the Districts seek to address these issues using strategies within their purview, recognizing they do not have the infrastructure, capacity, or capabilities to spearhead coordination and collaboration efforts across the Greater Houston arts and culture ecosystem.

Thus, in addition to executing the four initiatives identified in the plan, the HCDs will be employing new approaches to cross-district collaboration that will allow them to effectively guide implementation, leverage the individual strengths of each HCD, and work to address the above barriers in their approach to implementing the strategies outlined in the plan. In doing so, the HCDs hope to model an approach to coordination and collaboration that supports the entire arts and cultural ecosystem.

In particular, participants highlighted five core historical barriers to collaboration across the arts and culture ecosystem in Houston:

- Lack of Shared Values & Goals
- Historical and Current Inequities Causing Harm & Distrust
- Differing Values & Perceptions of What Art Is Valuable, Leading to Exclusion
- Challenges with Information Flows & Communication
- Limited Funding, Resulting in a Scarcity Mindset

Specifically, the HCDs will:

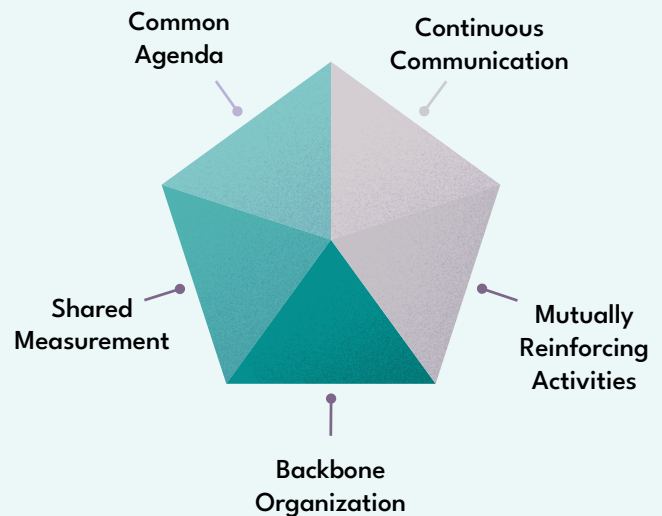
- Continue to engage a broad array of individuals and institutions in plan implementation
- Pilot a simple arts and culture directory within the HCDs
- Develop an "Artist and Community Accountability" body to help guide plan implementation - with representatives from a broad cross-section of organizations of different sizes across the districts, as well as independent artists. This will be developed once the project grows to cover multiple strategic initiatives.
- Employ the principles of collective impact in implementation
- Leverage shared resources across the seven HCD leaders

The HCDs will be employing new approaches to cross-district collaboration that will allow them to effectively guide implementation, leverage the individual strengths of each HCD, and work to address the above barriers in their approach to implementing the strategies outlined in the plan.

EMPLOYING THE PRINCIPLES OF COLLECTIVE IMPACT

Our implementation approach is inspired by the core principles of Stanford Social Innovation Review's Collective Impact model, to ensure efforts are grounded in best practices in collaboration for systems change across multiple entities.

For example, the planning process and evaluation has involved development of common agenda and begun infrastructure for shared measures. The backbone of this coalition will be composed of the leaders of the seven HCDs. Each of the HCDs, their member organizations, and their partners will be in continuous communication that will include the coordination of mutually reinforcing activities.



For the lifetime of this plan, the Cultural Districts will be **leveraging a set of shared resources to help drive plan implementation and facilitate strategy execution**. These roles should be thought of as a set of strategic supports to advance the plan across the ecosystem, while providing shared support to the CDs. See some potential areas below:

Governance & Coordination:

Develop recurring meeting agendas, determining alignment pre-meeting; Steer overall project by holding key relationships and guiding the governing body through decision-making processes.

Fundraising:

Steward individual, philanthropic, and corporate funding prospects; Apply for relevant grants.

Marketing & Communications:

Share opportunities, reminders, and updates with your collective communities, manage shared lists, work with press contacts

Evaluation:

Distribute annual surveys to HCD participants; Establish regular touchpoints and feedback mechanisms for participants

Acknowledgments

The Creative Connections 5-Year Plan was prepared by the Houston Cultural Districts in partnership with Trepwise.

The following individuals served as the representatives for each of the HCDs throughout the process:

ARTS DISTRICT:

Angela Carranza & Nicole Peralta

EAST END:

Dan Joyce

FIFTH WARD:

Harrison Guy

MIDTOWN:

Cynthia Alvarado

MUSEUM DISTRICT:

Rebecca Rabinow & Alison Weaver

HOUSTON THEATER DISTRICT:

James Nelson (August 2022 - October 2022) ;
Hillary J. Hart (October 2022 - February 2024)

THIRD WARD:

Robert “RUEROB” Jackson (December 2022 - November 2023) ;
Jaison Oliver (November 2023 - February 2024)

CROSS-DISTRICT SUPPORT:

Marci Dallas

The following individuals served as the consulting team from Trepwise, which led plan development.

PROJECT LEAD:

Isaac MacDonald

PROJECT SUPPORT:

Khi Van Allen

PROJECT ADVISOR:

Palmer Mills

EVALUATION ADVISOR:

Jana Fredricks

Additionally, this plan would not exist without the incredible time and investment provided by individuals and organizations across Houston. There were almost 1000 individuals engaged in this process, and we extend our gratitude to each and every one of them.

We would like to provide special thanks to Bao-Long Chu and Ann B. Stern of Houston Endowment, for providing the investment, support, and grounding vision needed to launch this planning and evaluation process.

RESEARCH FINDINGS

Ecosystem Needs: Creators

INSIGHTS FROM RESEARCH & STAKEHOLDER DISCOVERY

Currently many artists cannot afford to live and work in Houston: as of 2021 the majority of renters in the city are cost-burdened¹ and 54% of artists surveyed for this project do not have access to the space they need to move their creative practice forward.

Artists and creatives in Houston perceive **significant barriers to growing their practices**, and in particular view **accessing grants** as a time consuming process where resources often go to a recurring group of "insiders."

Stakeholders frequently spoke of the challenges of running arts enterprises — the pressures felt by businesses and orgs, the desire for increased opportunities to sell and exhibit, and the sense that citywide **lack of awareness of the arts and cultural offerings in Houston is limiting the potential** for widespread audience engagement.

Respondents reflected passionately about the **importance of youth education**, highlighting great work that is happening with nonprofits, but also desire for more standardized opportunities for the next generation to learn and be inspired.



Creators: Artists and creatives who have the resources to live, create, and prosper

"We use art to express ourselves, not words. I see many missed opportunities because of the hoops we go through trying to apply for grants! Hopefully there is an easier way in the near future or access to someone who helps us directly write the grant."

"Multiple, long lasting funding opportunities that allow for little-known or emerging artists and culture-makers to thrive are essential to any vision of Houston's future."

"If artists can afford to live, they can afford to create."

RESEARCH FINDINGS

Ecosystem Needs: Experiences

INSIGHTS FROM RESEARCH & STAKEHOLDER DISCOVERY

There is broad agreement that **Houston is rich with cultural assets** (including museums, performing arts venues, historical neighborhood-based organizations, and more) and also that the city has **struggled to convert those assets into widely-known and accessible experiences**.

Respondents discussed the role of **events and festivals** at catalyzing arts and cultural tourism and bringing people together. While Houston has festivals, there is not one at the scale of SXSW or Art Basel, which have established and reinforced Austin & Miami as cultural arts destinations.

Stakeholders noted that the larger institutions have broadened their efforts at outreach, representation, and engagement, but that there were still opportunities for **increased inclusivity in all arts programming**- via thoughtful outreach, reduced financial barriers, and improved accessibility via better parking or transit solutions.

Many people celebrated the murals throughout the city, but expressed desire for **multidisciplinary art to be more deeply integrated into public spaces and green spaces**.

Respondents spoke of an opportunity to establish **neighborhood identity through creative placemaking and placekeeping**, featuring art that is reflective of cultural histories while putting guardrails in place to mitigate displacement.



Experiences: Accessible arts and cultural experiences that create a sense of place and reflect the city's diversity & vibrancy

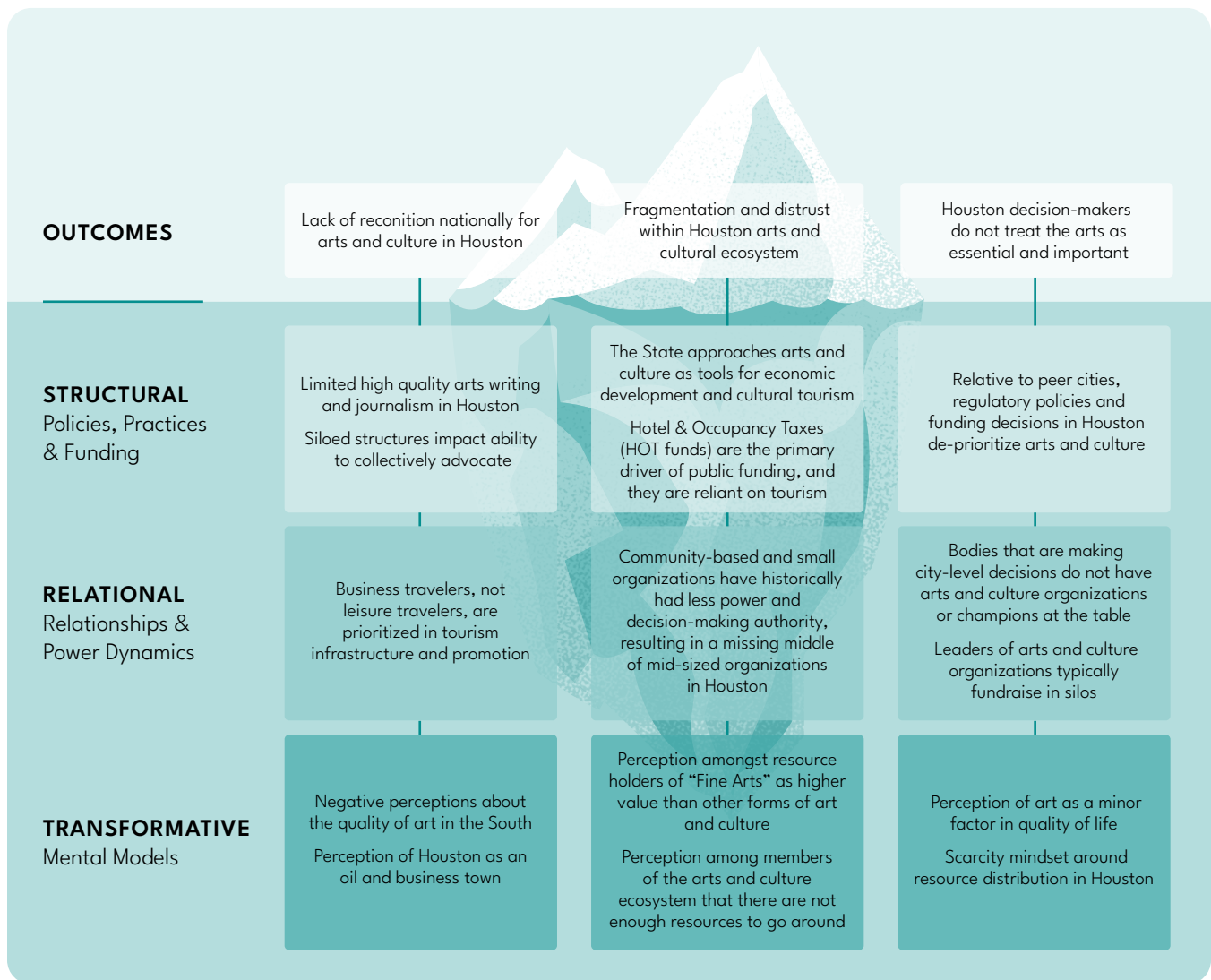
"I envision a future where the art reflects the cultural diversity of Houston's population, supporting not just black and white artists but also Asian, Latin and Middle Eastern artists included in the most diverse city in America."

"I would like to see activities that promote the arts and culture including proposals that are historically relevant but also experimental and contemporary. I would like to see that identity is woven and built, and not just represented in a static way."

"We tend to wash away the sense of place in Houston"

Water of Systems Change

As described on page 11, this plan's systems change approach is informed by FSG's Water of Systems Change framework, which encourages strategy to look beyond the surface level outcomes, and to instead focus on how (1) policies, practices, & funding, (2) relationships & power dynamics, and (3) mental models may need to shift to create sustained impact. Based upon the learnings from discovery, we have outlined some of the underlying conditions that contribute to the outcomes we seek to shift in the Houston arts and culture ecosystem. If we want to change the outcomes at the top of the icebergs, we will need to address some of the underlying structures and narratives that are contributing to them.



A1. Capacity-Building for Arts Advocacy

AUDIENCE	OUTPUTS	PLAN MEASURES	
		SHORT-TERM OUTCOMES	LONG-TERM OUTCOMES
<i>Who participates in the program intervention of trainings and activations?</i>	<i>In the near-term what do we hope to see?</i>	<i>What will participants do, think, and feel after completing the program?</i>	<i>What will participants do later?</i>
Artists and Creative Practitioners Arts workers at arts nonprofits and for-profits Arts leaders across Houston, representing small, mid-sized and large organizations Arts appreciators, including CD residents, volunteers and advocates Business and municipal leaders (some within trainings, some receiving testimony) Cultural District partners (education, community- based, and faith-based orgs)	# of participants involved in trainings # of participants attending advocacy forums Diversity of participants (role in arts ecosystem) Participant satisfaction with program delivery model	FOSTER CIVIC PRIDE & ENGAGEMENT <i>(Community Cohesion)</i> A) Participants will better understand how to advocate for the arts and culture sector B) Participants will better understand the needs of the arts and culture sector C) Participants will understand the importance of organized advocacy efforts at the city and state level BUILD CONNECTIONS WITHIN HOUSTON'S ARTS + CULTURAL SECTOR <i>(Community Cohesion)</i> D) Participants will feel more connected to the arts and cultural sector	FOSTER CIVIC PRIDE & ENGAGEMENT <i>(Community Cohesion)</i> A) Participants will contribute their time and energy toward arts advocacy efforts as a participant or organizer B) Participants will use common language to articulate sector-wide needs and policy goals BUILD CONNECTIONS WITHIN HOUSTON'S ARTS + CULTURAL SECTOR <i>(Community Cohesion)</i> C) Participants will participate in a network of arts and culture policy advocates in Houston D) The arts and cultural sector will develop, iterate, and progress their policy agenda

A2. Partnerships & Relationship-Building

AUDIENCE	OUTPUTS	PLAN MEASURES	
		SHORT-TERM OUTCOMES	LONG-TERM OUTCOMES
<i>Who participates in the program activations of targeted meetings and relationship building?</i>	<i>In the near-term what do we hope to see?</i>	<i>What will participants do, think, and feel after completing the program?</i>	<i>What will participants do later?</i>
Mayor of Houston Mayor's Office of Cultural Affairs (MOCA) Houston Arts Alliance Greater Houston Partnerships Houston First Central Houston Texas Commission of the Arts (TCA) Elected Officials	# of meetings # of targets engaged # of arts & cultural representatives sitting on key bodies	CATALYZE CROSS-SECTOR PARTNERSHIPS <i>(Community Cohesion)</i> A) Participants will be more aware of the ways that arts + culture bring value to the city of Houston B) Participants will better understand how they can benefit from collaborating with the arts + culture sector C) Participants will develop cross-sector relationships with arts + culture leaders D) Participants will be interested in engaging the arts + culture sector to accomplish common goals E) Participants will be more aware of the goals and interests of the arts + culture sector	CATALYZE CROSS-SECTOR PARTNERSHIPS <i>(Community Cohesion)</i> Participants will build enduring relationships with arts and cultural representatives, reflected in coalitions and partnerships ATTRACT VISITORS + INCREASE ACCESS TO ARTS + CULTURE <i>(Cultural Vibrancy)</i> Intentional inclusion of arts and culture in major tourism events and spending GENERATE NEW BUSINESS OPPORTUNITIES FOR NONPROFITS, BUSINESSES, + ARTISTS <i>(Economic Development)</i> Inclusion of arts and culture in economic development and business attraction conversations and plans

B1. Unified District Activations

AUDIENCE	OUTPUTS	PLAN MEASURES	
		SHORT-TERM OUTCOMES	LONG-TERM OUTCOMES
<i>Who participates in the program by viewing the art activations?</i>	<i>In the near-term what do we hope to see?</i>	<i>What will participants do, think, and feel after completing the program?</i>	<i>What will participants do later?</i>
A) Houston residents B) Houston visitors C) Arts appreciators D) Cultural District Residents E) Cultural District Visitors	Total \$ directly paid to artists # of local artists engaged # of partners # of art organizations engaged in shared activations	ATTRACT VISITORS + INCREASE ACCESS TO ARTS + CULTURE A) Attendees will be more aware of districts as hubs of arts and cultural experiences B) Participants will be more likely to attend the activation events and invite others FOSTER CREATIVITY, WELLBEING, AND ARTS APPRECIATION C) Attendees will feel more inspired, creative, and peaceful; they will be exposed to new ideas and art forms CELEBRATE NEIGHBORHOOD CREATIVITY + PRESERVE CULTURAL LEGACY D) Attendees will better understand the creativity, culture, and history of CD neighborhoods GATHER FRIENDS + FAMILIES E) Attendees will feel closer to friends and family who also attended FOSTER CIVIC PRIDE + ENGAGEMENT F) Attendees will feel proud of Houston's arts and culture G) Residents will feel proud of their neighborhood's cultural contributions BUILD CONNECTIONS WITHIN HOUSTON'S ARTS + CULTURAL SECTOR E) There will be replicable infrastructure for organizing and marketing multi-district events and offerings GENERATE NEW BUSINESS OPPORTUNITIES FOR DISTRICT NONPROFITS, BUSINESSES, + ARTISTS F) District businesses and organizations will experience increased sales and visitation G) Participating artists will gain notoriety and receive compensation	ATTRACT VISITORS + INCREASE ACCESS TO ARTS + CULTURE A) Attendees will return to CD's for arts and cultural experiences FOSTER CREATIVITY, WELLBEING, AND ARTS APPRECIATION B) Attendees will value arts and culture as essential to their health and wellbeing CELEBRATE NEIGHBORHOOD CREATIVITY + PRESERVE CULTURAL LEGACY C) Cultural District neighborhoods will have distinct creative and cultural identities GATHER FRIENDS + FAMILIES D) Attendees will have a strong sense of support and community FOSTER CIVIC PRIDE + ENGAGEMENT E) Attendees will be active and engaged citizens F) Residents will invest in their community BUILD CONNECTIONS WITHIN HOUSTON'S ARTS + CULTURAL SECTOR G) CD's will continue co-producing events and offerings SUPPORT THE FINANCIAL SUSTAINABILITY AND GROWTH OF DISTRICT NONPROFITS, BUSINESSES, + ARTISTS

B2. Houston Stories to New Audiences

AUDIENCE	OUTPUTS	PLAN MEASURES	
		SHORT-TERM OUTCOMES	LONG-TERM OUTCOMES
<i>Who participates in the program by viewing the art activations?</i>	<i>In the near-term what do we hope to see?</i>	<i>What will participants do, think, and feel after completing the program?</i>	<i>What will participants do later?</i>
A) Houston residents who are unfamiliar with some part of Arts & Culture in Houston B) Individuals from other places who are unfamiliar with Houston as a center for cultural arts.	Total \$ directly paid to creative storytellers # of assets created and distributed # of people reached through film screenings, digital streaming or other deployment of content # of people reached through strategic public relations	ATTRACT VISITORS + INCREASE ACCESS TO ARTS + CULTURE A) Audience members will be more aware of Houston as a center for arts and cultural experiences CELEBRATE NEIGHBORHOOD CREATIVITY + PRESERVE CULTURAL LEGACY D) Audience members will better understand the creativity, culture, and history of Houston's neighborhoods FOSTER CIVIC PRIDE + ENGAGEMENT E) Local audience members will feel proud of Houston's arts and culture BUILD CONNECTIONS WITHIN HOUSTON'S ARTS + CULTURAL SECTOR F) There will be replicable infrastructure for sharing Houston's stories to New Audiences GENERATE NEW BUSINESS OPPORTUNITIES FOR DISTRICT NONPROFITS, BUSINESSES, + ARTISTS G) Participating artists or creatives will gain notoriety and receive compensation	ATTRACT VISITORS + INCREASE ACCESS TO ARTS + CULTURE A) Those who are reached by the stories will consider engaging more deeply B) Audience members will be more likely to attend a cultural event if they visit Houston SUPPORT THE FINANCIAL SUSTAINABILITY AND GROWTH OF DISTRICT NONPROFITS, BUSINESSES, + ARTISTS C) Audience members will be more likely to invest in Houston arts and Cultural offerings D) District businesses and organizations will experience increased sales and visitation